ENGLISH C1 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Evidential distance

Attribute claims with reportedly, according to, appear to and be said to while separating source from certainty. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use evidential distance to show whether information is observed, reported or inferred and limit the writer's commitment while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Attribute claims with reportedly, according to, appear to and be said to while separating source from certainty.

MODEL

The device appears to have failed during transport.

source marker + proposition | subject + appear/be reported + infinitive

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main evidential distance patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses show whether information is observed, reported or inferred and limit the writer's commitment.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in news, research summaries, investigations and responsible professional writing.

Build meaning before form

Attribute claims with reportedly, according to, appear to and be said to while separating source from certainty.

What evidential distance communicates

Attribute claims with reportedly, according to, appear to and be said to while separating source from certainty.

The central purpose is to show whether information is observed, reported or inferred and limit the writer’s commitment. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The device appears to have failed during transport.	a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof
The company is reported to be considering a merger.	a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting
According to the inspection log, the fault began at 03:10.	information explicitly assigned to a traceable source

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: source marker + proposition | subject + appear/be reported + infinitive. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “The device appears to have failed during transport.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Observed indication	appear/seem + to-infinitive	The device appears to have failed during transport.
Attributed report	subject + be reported/said + to-infinitive	The company is reported to be considering a merger.
Named source	according to + source	According to the inspection log, the fault began at 03:10.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof	Observed indication
a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting	Attributed report
information explicitly assigned to a traceable source	Named source

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in news, research summaries, investigations and responsible professional writing. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04	05
source marker	proposition	subject	appear/be reported	infinitive

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: show whether information is observed, reported or inferred and limit the writer's commitment.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits news, research summaries, investigations and responsible professional writing.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Observed indication	appear/seem + to-infinitive	The device appears to have failed during transport.
Attributed report	subject + be reported/said + to-infinitive	The company is reported to be considering a merger.
Named source	according to + source	According to the inspection log, the fault began at 03:10.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The device appears to have failed during transport.	a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof
The company is reported to be considering a merger.	a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting
According to the inspection log, the fault began at 03:10.	information explicitly assigned to a traceable source

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not present appears to as confirmed fact.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use an unattributed reporting passive to disguise unsupported speculation.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use according to me for an ordinary personal opinion.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof?

OPTIONS The device appears to have failed during transport. · The company is reported to be considering a merger. · According to the inspection log, the fault began at 03:10.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting?

OPTIONS The company is reported to be considering a merger. · According to the inspection log, the fault began at 03:10. · The device appears to have failed during transport.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: information explicitly assigned to a traceable source?

OPTIONS According to the inspection log, the fault began at 03:10. · The device appears to have failed during transport. · The company is reported to be considering a merger.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The device appears to have failed during transport.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof · a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting · information explicitly assigned to a traceable source

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “The company is reported to be considering a merger.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting · information explicitly assigned to a traceable source · a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “According to the inspection log, the fault began at 03:10.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS information explicitly assigned to a traceable source · a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof · a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"The device appears to have failed during transport." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Observed indication / Attributed report / Named source · Gap 2: a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof / a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting / information explicitly assigned to a traceable source

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"The company is reported to be considering a merger." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Attributed report / Named source / Observed indication · Gap 2: a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting / information explicitly assigned to a traceable source / a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"According to the inspection log, the fault began at 03:10." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Named source / Observed indication / Attributed report · Gap 2: information explicitly assigned to a traceable source / a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof / a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof: _____. Choose the model that expresses a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting: _____. Choose the model that expresses information explicitly assigned to a traceable source: _____. Choose the model built with appear/seem + to-infinitive: _____. Choose the model built with subject + be reported/said + to-infinitive: _____. Choose the model built with according to + source: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

According to the inspection log, the fault began at 03:10. · The company is reported to be considering a merger. · The device appears to have failed during transport.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The device _____ during transport. The company _____ a merger. _____, the fault began at 03:10. State the full structural pattern for Observed indication: _____. State the full structural pattern for Attributed report: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The available signs suggest transport damage.” using the Observed indication pattern to express a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “Reports say the company may consider a merger.” using the Attributed report pattern to express a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “The inspection log records a 03:10 start.” using the Named source pattern to express information explicitly assigned to a traceable source.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The available signs suggest transport damage.” using the Observed indication pattern to express a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Observed indication to express a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Attributed report to express a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Named source to express information explicitly assigned to a traceable source, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The device appears to have failed during transport.

Observed indication is the best match because a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof.

A2

The company is reported to be considering a merger.

Attributed report is the best match because a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting.

A3

According to the inspection log, the fault began at 03:10.

Named source is the best match because information explicitly assigned to a traceable source.

A4

a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof

The Observed indication pattern communicates a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof.

A5

a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting

The Attributed report pattern communicates a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting.

A6

information explicitly assigned to a traceable source

The Named source pattern communicates information explicitly assigned to a traceable source.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Observed indication / a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof

The structure belongs to the Observed indication pattern. Its communicative purpose is a conclusion based on observable signs rather than direct proof.

B2

Attributed report / a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting

The structure belongs to the Attributed report pattern. Its communicative purpose is a claim attributed to unnamed or external reporting.

B3

Named source / information explicitly assigned to a traceable source

The structure belongs to the Named source pattern. Its communicative purpose is information explicitly assigned to a traceable source.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The device appears to have failed during transport.

Observed indication: appear/seem + to-infinitive.

C2

The company is reported to be considering a merger.

Attributed report: subject + be reported/said + to-infinitive.

C3

According to the inspection log, the fault began at 03:10.

Named source: according to + source.

C4

The device appears to have failed during transport.

Observed indication: appear/seem + to-infinitive.

C5

The company is reported to be considering a merger.

Attributed report: subject + be reported/said + to-infinitive.

C6

According to the inspection log, the fault began at 03:10.

Named source: according to + source.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

appears to have failed

Observed indication requires “appears to have failed” in this model. appear/seem + to-infinitive.

D2

is reported to be considering

Attributed report requires “is reported to be considering” in this model. subject + be reported/said + to-infinitive.

D3

According to the inspection log

Named source requires “According to the inspection log” in this model. according to + source.

D4

appear/seem + to-infinitive

Observed indication is built as appear/seem + to-infinitive.

D5

subject + be reported/said + to-infinitive

Attributed report is built as subject + be reported/said + to-infinitive.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The device appears to have failed during transport.

appear/seem + to-infinitive. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended observed indication effect.

E2

The company is reported to be considering a merger.

subject + be reported/said + to-infinitive. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended attributed report effect.

E3

According to the inspection log, the fault began at 03:10.

according to + source. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended named source effect.

E4

The device appears to have failed during transport.

appear/seem + to-infinitive. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended observed indication effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The device appears to have failed during transport. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses appear/seem + to-infinitive accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The company is reported to be considering a merger. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses subject + be reported/said + to-infinitive accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

According to the inspection log, the fault began at 03:10. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses according to + source accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____